

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

A FRIENDLY MATCH?

Odisha's BJP leaders couldn't believe their ears when they heard Prime Minister Narendra Modi calling Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik his *mitr* (friend) at a state event in Sambalpur on February 3. In his first public meeting in Odisha (which goes to the polls in the next few months) in 2024, Modi didn't take a single swipe at the ruling Biju Janata Dal, training all his caustic ire on the Congress instead. And this when the *karyakartas* have been working day and night to bring down Patnaik raj. The admiration was mutual, to boot. Naveen Babu was equally fulsome in his praise of "Modiji", saying he has "set a new direction for India...we are on the path to becoming an economic powerhouse". With the general election coming up, the flummoxed Odisha BJP has resigned itself to doing its best in this season of about-turns. They only have to look at neighbouring Bihar.

The Hex Factor

Nitish Kumar may have been Bihar chief minister from 2015, but the state has seen seven deputy CMs since. Some say the post itself is jinxed; others think they know where the problem lies—5, Deshratna Marg, the official residence of the deputy CM. RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav inaugurated it in 2016, only to have his wicket fall by July 2017. The BJP's Sushil Modi, who succeeded Yadav, moved in in February 2019. A year later, the BJP and Nitish were still together, but Sushil was no longer part of the picture. The next two residents—Tarkishore Prasad (BJP) and Tejashwi—also saw their stay cut short when Nitish switched sides in 2022 and 2024. Now, with a new JD(U)-BJP regime in place, it remains to be seen which of the two new deputy CMs, **Samrat Choudhary** and **Vijay Sinha,** gets allotted the bungalow, and what fate awaits the resident.





Changing Times



Telangana chief minister **A. Revanth Reddy** has decided that the state code will henceforth be 'TG' and not 'TS', as his predecessor, K. Chandrashekar Rao, had fixed. All vehicle registrations will, therefore, now change. As will the state emblem and statues of Telangana Talli (mother of Telangana) that have mushroomed across the state. Poet Ande Sri's *Jaya Jaya He Telangana* is also set to become the state song. Looks like the Congress regime is determined to create a *kotha* (new) Telangana by the time the general election rolls in.



Admission Test

Such is the rush to join the BJP in Gujarat that the party has now formed a dedicated panel to review new inductees. Since the beginning of the year, thousands of supporters of two sitting MLAs—AAP's Bhupendra Bhayani and Chirag Patel of the Congress—have joined the BJP along with the leaders. Another Congress MLA, **C.J. Chavda**, has quit and is expected to join soon. The six-member panel says it will review the antecedents of those joining to filter out "malfeasant elements". Since 2017, over three dozen sitting MLAs and MPs of the Congress have jumped ship.

THE BATTLE FOR KANNAUJ

Akhilesh Yadav's wife Dimple Yadav may have lost the election from the Kannauj Lok Sabha seat in Uttar Pradesh in 2019, but the constituency is still considered a Samajwadi Party (SP) stronghold. There is now talk that the SP chief himself might contest from here. But the ex-CM will not have it easy. On February 3, Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath kickstarted the UP poll campaign from Kannauj with a big rally. He also laid the foundation stone for development schemes worth Rs 352 crore. Akhilesh has his task cut out: competing with the BJP's largesse.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Kaushik Deka with Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Amitabh Srivastava, Ashish Misra, Jumana Shah and Amarnath K. Menon